PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Land Rover 90 / 110 / Defender

1983–2016 · One Ten · Ninety · 127 / 130 · NAS 110

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Paperwork and VIN first**
  Match the VIN plate on the brake servo with the number stamped on the front chassis rail. For gray-market imports, make sure the build date really is 25+ years old; federal agents have seized Defenders over alleged VIN swaps, and owners without paperwork lost them.
- [ ] **Rear crossmember**
  It takes towing and winching loads and rots from the inside out. Fibreglass, fresh underseal or chunky checker plate can hide it, so get under with a light and ask for the underside to be cleaned.
- [ ] **Bulkhead, footwells and outriggers**
  Check the bulkhead sides, bottom corners and the top under the vent flaps, plus the footwells and the outrigger behind the front wheel. Repair is real money; a new bulkhead runs about £1,600 in the UK.
- [ ] **Swivel balls and steering play**
  Pitted chrome balls chew their seals and wear the swivel pins. Vague or wobbly steering with excess play points here; budget for rebuild kits if the balls are rusty or weeping.
- [ ] **Transfer box noise and leaks**
  Listen for whine and clunks in low range. Oil leaking from the LT230 can coat the transmission handbrake shoes; check the rear output seal and intermediate shaft area.
- [ ] **300Tdi timing belt history**
  Ask whether the revised timing kit (Land Rover STC4096L-type, with flanged crank pulley and spaced idler) has been fitted. Early setups could let the belt track off and wear.
- [ ] **Td5 oil in the loom**
  Pull the barrel connector between the engine and injector harnesses. Oil there means it's wicking toward the ECU under the seat.
- [ ] **NAS authenticity**
  A real 1993 NAS 110 or 1994–97 NAS 90 carries a numbered NAS badge and a US-market VIN. Plenty of Euro trucks have been dressed up as NAS; check against the registry discussions on Defender Source.

YEARS TO KNOW

1990	SWEET SPOT	200Tdi direct-injection diesel (107 hp); 127 becomes the Defender 130. ECD calls the 200Tdi one of the most dependable engines ever fitted to a Defender
1994	SWEET SPOT	300Tdi and R380 gearbox; NAS Defender 90 (3.9 V8, manual) goes on sale. Specialists rate the 300Tdi the most reliable Defender engine; check the revised timing-belt kit
1998–2002	BEWARE	Early '10P' Td5s: oil-pump-drive and head-stud failures (fixed within two years) and cylinder heads that crack around the injectors. 15P engines and '52-plate-on trucks are fine

2011	SWEET SPOT	PistonHeads' sweet spot among the Puma Defenders: a 2011 truck, 2.4 or the 2.2 that followed, for the best mix of 'sortedness'

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Driveshaft nuts replaced with wrong size at port of entry**
  1995 · NHTSA 95V099000
- ☐ **Battery hazardous-substance warning label missing**
  1992–1995 · NHTSA 96V108000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **VIN plate and chassis stamp**
  The VIN plate sits on the bulkhead or brake servo under the bonnet; match it to the number stamped on the front chassis rail and the title. For an import, the build date must really be 25+ years old.
- ☐ **Rest-of-world VIN**
  Ninety/One Ten VINs start SALLD. Position 6 is V for Ninety or H for One Ten; position 7 is body (A regular, B Ninety Station Wagon, H High Capacity Pickup, M One Ten Station Wagon); position 8 is engine (B 2.5 TD, C 2.5 D, D 2.5 petrol, F 2.5 Tdi, G 2.25 D, H 2.25 petrol, V V8).
- ☐ **Genuine NAS trucks**
  NAS Defenders carry a US-format 17-character VIN (RM Sotheby's examples: SALDV2285RA941249 for a 1994 D90, SALDV2246VA118787 for a 1997), a numbered NAS badge, a full external roll cage, larger side indicators and taillights, factory air and four-wheel discs. All have the 3.9 or 4.0 V8.
- ☐ **200Tdi or 300Tdi?**
  The 200Tdi has two V-belts and a big aluminium block-to-sump strengthener; the 300Tdi has a single serpentine belt, no strengthener, a smaller water pump mounted higher and a piston-type vacuum pump.
- ☐ **Heritage certificate**
  The British Motor Museum's Heritage Certificate copies the factory ledger entry (build and despatch dates, engine number, colour, equipment) and covers Land Rovers from 1948 on. Useful for proving a build date or NAS spec.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-rover/defender-90-110/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks